ARAB NOMAD FEST · TAGHAZOUT · 2026

The Five Senses *Formula™*

by Nadia Minds

A neuroscience-based sensory method to calm your brain for a happier life.



BEFORE I INTRODUCE MYSELF

Let’s do a *Five Senses Check-In.*

Scan the QR code and answer fast, with your gut. You have two minutes.

thefivesensesformula.com/checkin3

YOUR RESULTS

Are you *surprised?*



Touch
how you move



Smell
how you breathe



Taste
how you fuel



Sound
what you let in



Sight
light and screens

regulated strained dysregulated (11 out of 15 or more)

Who would like to share what came out?

NOW, WHO I AM

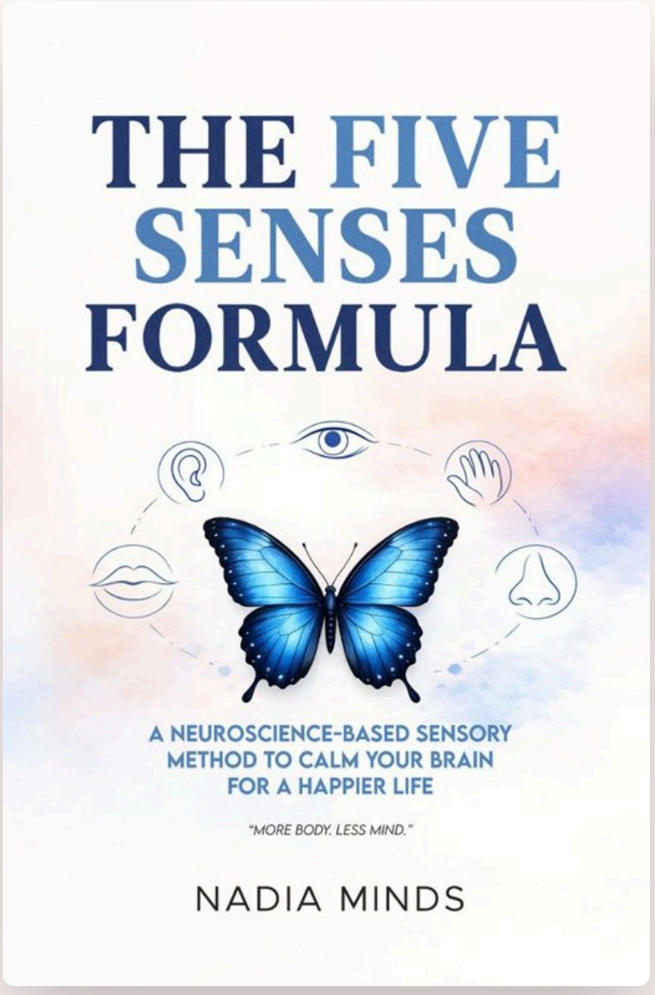
I am *Nadia.*

🧠 **ADHD coach and business doctor**

🔬 **Independent neuroscience researcher**

📖 **Author** of The Five Senses Formula, **over 1,500 copies sold**

The Five Senses Formula is a neuroscience-based method to calm your brain for a happier life.



WHAT THE CHECK-IN MEASURED

Five senses, *one system.*

The inputs you gave your body are received by your nervous system, the state you run in. It decides how everything else sounds.



TO EXPLAIN WHAT THAT MEANS

I use one picture: a song and a radio.

THE PICTURE TO REMEMBER

Your brain is *a song.* Your nervous system is *the radio.*

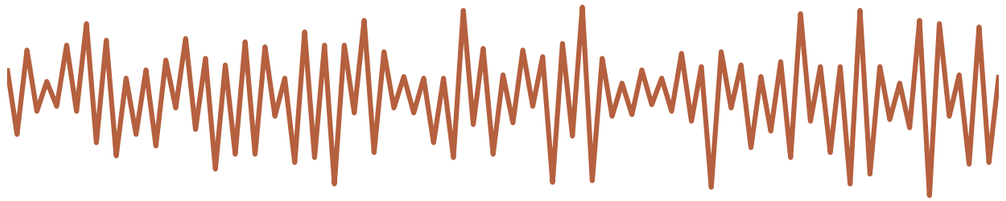
The song is the brain you were born with. The radio decides how that song reaches you.

Your Check-In scored the radio. As an ADHD coach and business doctor, this is where I always start.



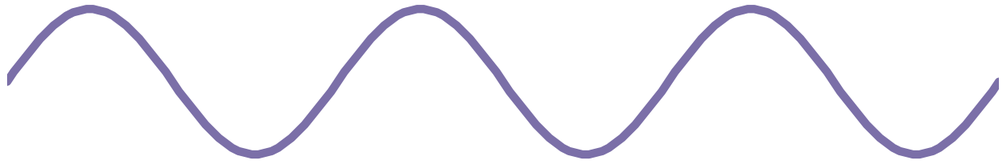
WHEN THE RADIO DRIFTS OFF THE STATION

The song turns *to static.*



Not tuned

Volume too high or too low. Your focus, mood, sleep and patience stop matching your actions, and you react instead of deciding.



Tuned

The song is clear.

WHAT IS INSIDE THE RADIO

Two characters decide *who leads.*



The alarm

THE AMYGDALA

Where: deep in the brain, an almond-sized cluster

Job: scans for danger and reacts in milliseconds

Style: fast, loud, felt in the body



The planner

THE PREFRONTAL CORTEX

Where: right behind your forehead

Job: plans, weighs and chooses

Style: slower, quieter, in words

WHO ARRIVES FIRST?



Gas pedal down: the alarm leads

Brake pedal on: the planner leads

Sources: LeDoux, The Emotional Brain (1996) · Arnsten 2009, Nat Rev Neurosci 10:410-422

HOW THE RADIO WORKS

Two modes *set who leads.*



Sympathetic: the gas pedal

Alert, fast, ready to act: threat, deadlines, anything new.

the alarm leads



Parasympathetic: the brake pedal

Slow, safe, ready to repair: digest, sleep, connect.

the planner can lead

THE POINT

You need both. Trouble starts when one gets stuck.

MODE 1 · THE GAS PEDAL

Constantly in sympathetic? *Ask yourself.*



Do you feel irritable over small things?



Do you reach for your phone before you open your eyes?



Do you run on coffee and skip meals?



Are your jaw clenched and your shoulders up, right now?



Are you answering messages at midnight, in yet another time zone?



Are you wired and tired at the same time?

WHAT HAPPENS INSIDE

1. **The alarm rings.**
2. **Adrenaline** speeds your heart within seconds. **Cortisol** keeps you on alert for hours.
3. When they stay high, **the planner goes quiet.**
4. You react instead of choosing.

AFTER A FEW YEARS

It starts to feel like your personality.

Sources: LeDoux (1996) · Sapolsky, Why Zebras Don’t Get Ulcers (2004) · Arnsten 2009, Nat Rev Neurosci 10:410-422

MODE 2 · THE BRAKE PEDAL

Parasympathetic: *when did you last feel...*

🎨

creative, without forcing it?

🤝

truly present with someone, phone away?

🍽️

hungry, and tasted every bite?

😴

rested, after a full night of sleep?



calm, just watching the sunset?

😌

patient, when something went wrong?

WHAT HAPPENS INSIDE

1. The **vagus nerve** tells your body: safe.
2. A chemical called **acetylcholine** slows your heart. Breathing deepens and digestion switches on.
3. **The planner comes back.**
4. You feel creative, patient, present.

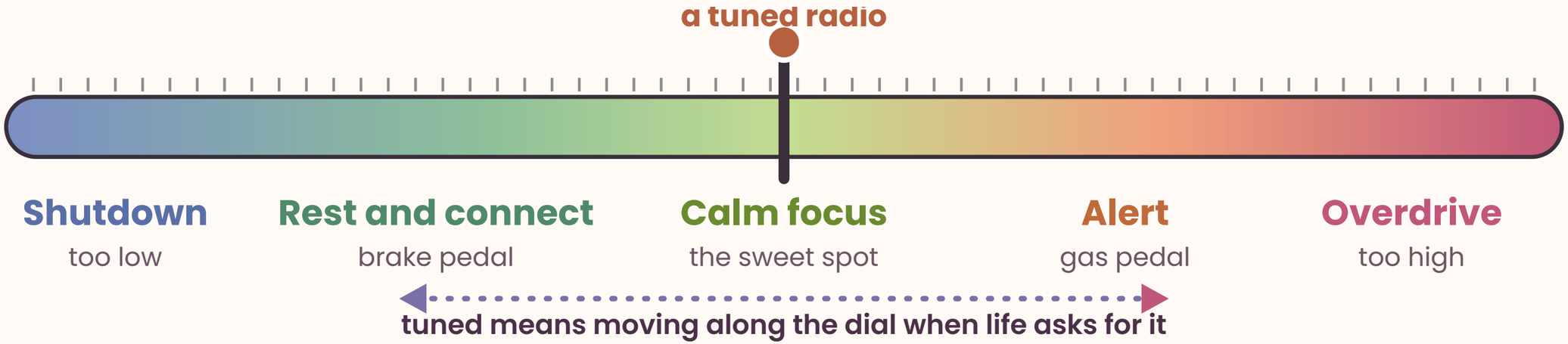
WHAT IT GIVES YOU

Patience, creativity, and clear decisions.

Sources: Thayer & Lane 2000, J Affect Disord 61:201-216 · Berthoud & Neuhuber 2000, Auton Neurosci 85:1-17

BOTH MODES TOGETHER

A tuned radio moves *along the dial.*



Stuck low: shutdown
Heavy mornings, cancelled plans, feeling nothing.

Stuck high: overdrive
Irritable, wired, unable to switch off.

WHY ARE WE TALKING ABOUT THIS?

Because your state decides *who shows up.*

Your state
gas or brake

Who leads
the alarm or the planner

Your actions
react, or choose

Your habits
what you repeat daily

Your identity
"this is who I am"

"I am not a patient person" often means "I am rarely in a state where patience is available."

Sources: Schwabe & Wolf 2009, J Neurosci 29:7191-7198 · Wood, Quinn & Kashy 2002, J Pers Soc Psychol 83:1281-1297 · Bem 1972, Adv Exp Soc Psychol 6:1-62

SO HOW DO WE CHANGE THE STATE?

The vagus nerve is the cable between *your body and your brain.*

About 80% of its signals travel up, from the body to the brain.



Sources: Berthoud & Neuhuber 2000, Autonomic Neuroscience 85:1-17

SO HOW DO WE TUNE THE RADIO?

Five doors into *the vagus nerve.*

Thinking takes the 20% road down. The senses take the 80% road up.



Touch
skin, muscles, movement



Smell
nose and breath



Taste
mouth and gut



Sound
ears, rhythm, silence



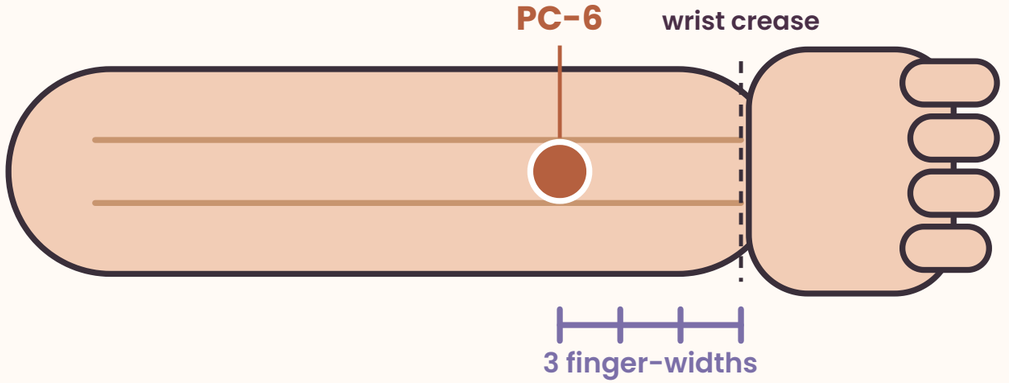
Sight
eyes and light

DOOR 1 · TOUCH · MOVE, THEN PRESS

Move first. Then *press one point.*

TRY IT NOW

Shake your arms and legs for 30 seconds. Then press PC-6 on your left wrist and breathe out slowly.



Sources: Meeusen & De Meirleir 1995, Sports Med 20:160-188 · Lee & Fan 2009, Cochrane CD003281

DOOR 2 · SMELL · BREATHE

Breathe out *longer than you breathe in.*

TRY IT NOW, TOGETHER

In through the nose for 4. Out slowly for 8. Three times. Follow the circle.



Sources: Russo et al. 2017, Breathe 13:298-309 · Herz 2004, Chem Senses 29:217-224

DOOR 3 · TASTE · THE ORDER YOU EAT

Eat in this order: *fibre, protein, then carbs.*

In Morocco: the salads first, then the tagine, the bread last.

TRY IT AT YOUR NEXT MEAL

Eat the vegetables first, then the protein, and leave the bread for the end.

1 

Vegetables first
Salad, cooked vegetables, anything green.

2 

Protein next
Fish, eggs, meat, legumes, the tagine.

3 

Carbs last
Bread, rice, pasta and sweets at the end.

Sources: Shukla et al. 2015, Diabetes Care 38:e98–e99 · Shukla et al. 2017, BMJ Open Diabetes Res Care 5:e000440

DOOR 4 · SOUND · SLOW, THEN SILENCE

A slow sound, *then silence.*

Choose music or the sea at about 60 beats a minute, like a resting heartbeat. Let your breathing follow it, and stay in the silence when it ends.

TRY IT NOW

Close your eyes for 20 seconds. Notice the loudest sound, then the quietest.



slow rhythm, about 60 beats a minute

then leave a silence

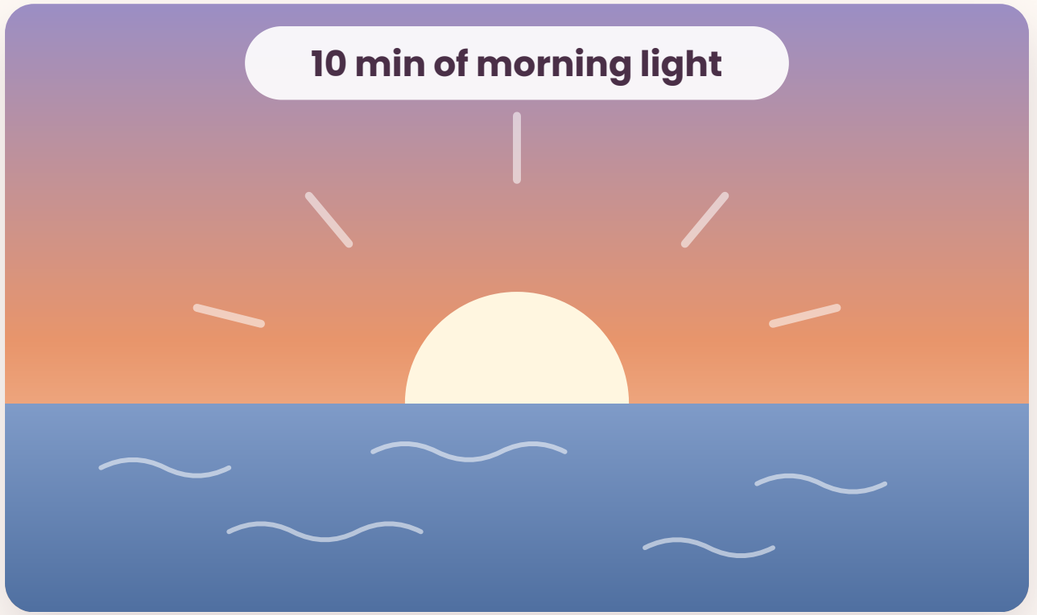
Sources: Bernardi, Porta & Sleight 2006, Heart 92:445-452 · LeDoux, The Emotional Brain (1996)

DOOR 5 · SIGHT · LIGHT AND HORIZON

Ten minutes of daylight, *before the phone.*

TOMORROW MORNING

Walk to the water with your coffee, face the light, and keep the phone in your pocket.



Sources: Berson, Dunn & Takao 2002, Science 295:1070-1073 · Wright et al. 2013, Curr Biol 23:1554-1558

FIVE DOORS, ONE RADIO

Start with *one sense a day.*



Touch

Move, then press PC-6



Smell

Breathe out longer, 4 in, 8 out



Taste

Vegetables, protein, carbs last



Sound

A slow track, then silence



Sight

Morning light, then the horizon

FROM THE BOOK

One sense regulates. Two shift your state. Three change your baseline.

THE KEY TAKEAWAY

You cannot think your way into a new identity *from a dysregulated nervous system.*

Regulation comes first, and it starts in the body.

THE ORDER

Regulate first. *Then build.*

1

Regulate

The body first, through the five senses.

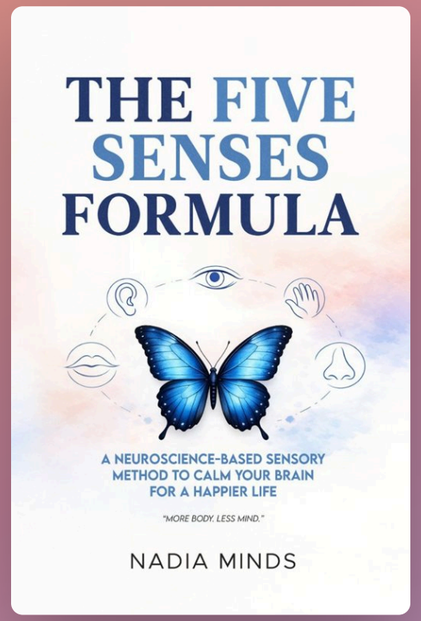
2

Build

Habits, work and identity, from a calm system.

CONTINUE THE WORK

Finish your Check-In. *Come and find me.*



The book

Your Check-In

@nadiaminds

I am here all week. Tell me which sense was your red one.